

STRUCTURED DEBATE & Persuasive Discussion

Water Safety HPE | Year 7-10 | Victorian Curriculum F-10 Version 2.0

Debate motions, argument scaffold, roles, timing guide, and assessment rubric.
Year 7-8 and Year 9-10 motions included. Cross-curricular: HPE + English VCELY.
VCHPEP125 | 126 | 129 | 143 | 144 | 147 | 148 | VCELY

Why Debate in a Water Safety Unit?

The evidence case for structured argument:

The deepest form of understanding is being able to argue both sides of a proposition. When students construct a case and defend it against challenge, they engage with evidence at a level passive delivery cannot produce. The critical thinking developed through debate is exactly the skill students need to resist peer pressure, evaluate risk, and advocate for safe behaviour in real situations.

Year 7-8:

Develops VCHPEP125/126 — supports the communication product task.

Year 9-10:

Develops VCHPEP143/144/147/148 — prepares for Policy Brief & Campaign tasks.

Cross-curricular:

Persuasive spoken language is a core VCELY outcome. Delivers HPE + English simultaneously.

Debate Motions — Year 7-8

How to choose a motion:

Choose motions that are genuinely contestable — real evidence exists on both sides. Avoid motions with obvious right answers. The goal is argument construction, not knowledge recall.

Y7-8 · M1 "This house believes that swimming ability alone is NOT enough to keep you safe near water."	Y7-8 · M2 "This house believes that peer pressure is the leading cause of dangerous behaviour near water for young people."
Y7-8 · M3 "This house believes that every Victorian secondary student should be required to complete CPR certification before Year 10."	Y7-8 · M4 "This house believes that rivers and dams are more dangerous than ocean beaches for Victorian teenagers."
Y7-8 · M5 "This house believes that alcohol near water should be completely banned in Victoria."	Y7-8 · M6 "This house believes that life-saving skills — not swimming skills — should be the primary focus of school water safety education."

Debate Motions — Year 9-10

Y9-10 · M1 "The Victorian Government should fund CALD community swim programs before expanding lifeguard patrols."	Y9-10 · M2 "The male drowning rate will not significantly improve until masculinity norms around risk-taking are directly challenged in schools."
Y9-10 · M3 "Mandatory pool fencing is a more cost-effective drowning prevention strategy than public awareness campaigns."	Y9-10 · M4 "Australia's approach to water safety education is superior to the UK's Float to Live model."

Y9-10 · M5

"Structural inequality — not individual behaviour — is the primary driver of drowning disproportionality in Victoria."

Y9-10 · M6

"Victorian drowning statistics should be disaggregated and publicly reported by demographic group to drive equitable policy responses."

Debate Structure — 50-Minute Class Format

Phase	Time	What happens
Preparation	12 min	Teams prepare arguments, allocate speakers, locate evidence
First speakers	8 min	Affirmative 1 (3 min) + Negative 1 (3 min) + crossfire (2 min)
Second speakers	8 min	Affirmative 2 (3 min) + Negative 2 (3 min) + crossfire (2 min)
Rebuttals	8 min	Affirmative rebuttal (3 min) + Negative rebuttal (3 min) + 2 min
Adjudication	14 min	Panel deliberates (5 min) + delivers verdict and feedback (9 min)

Roles

Role	Team	Responsibilities
First Affirmative	Affirmative	Define the motion. State the team's three arguments. Deliver the first argument with at least one cited statistic.
Second Affirmative	Affirmative	Rebuild the case after negative attack. Deliver the second and third arguments. Begin counter-attacking.
Affirmative Rebuttal	Affirmative	Identify the key clash point. Attack the negative's strongest argument. Summarise why the affirmative wins. No new arguments.
First Negative	Negative	Accept or challenge the definition. Rebut the affirmative's first argument. State the negative's three arguments.
Second Negative	Negative	Rebuild the negative case. Deliver second and third arguments. Counter-attack each affirmative argument with evidence.
Negative Rebuttal	Negative	Identify the key clash point. Argue why the negative wins it. Summarise two strongest arguments. No new arguments.
Adjudication Panel (x3)	Observer	Take notes under: Matter, Manner, Method. Reach a majority verdict. Deliver specific feedback to each team.

Argument Construction Scaffold

Block 1 — Opening & Claim

State your position clearly in one sentence. No hedging. Commit to it.

"We argue that [position] because [one-line reason]. This matters because [connection to Victorian data or lived impact]."

Tip: Common mistake: starting with "I think..." weakens the claim. State it as fact you will prove.

Block 2 — Evidence & Reasoning

Cite at least one specific primary source. Explain WHY the evidence supports the claim — do not assume the connection is obvious.

"According to the Life Saving Victoria 2023-24 Victorian Drowning Report, [statistic]. This shows that [explanation]. If [implication], then [connect to the motion]."

Tip: A-standard reasoning explains the causal mechanism, not just the correlation.

Block 3 — Counter-Argument & Rebuttal

Acknowledge the strongest opposing argument. Then refute it — not by dismissing it, but by explaining why it is outweighed or limited.

"The opposing team may argue that [state their point accurately]. While true in [limited context], this does not apply here because [specific reason]."

Tip: Failure to acknowledge any opposing argument at all is the most common reason debates are lost at adjudication.

Block 4 — Summary & Impact

Restate your claim in fresh language. Connect it to real-world consequences.

"In summary, we have shown that [restate claim differently]. If the opposing position were accepted, the result would be [specific real-world consequence]."

Tip: End with a forward-looking statement — not a backward summary.

The AREA Method — Rebuttal in Real Time

A **ACKNOWLEDGE** *"The opposing team claims that..."*

R **REFUTE** *"However, this fails because..."*

E **EVIDENCE** *"The LSV data shows that..."*

A **AFFIRM** *"This strengthens our case because..."*

Assessment Rubric

Criterion	A — Excellent	B — Proficient	C — Developing	D/E — Beginning
Evidence quality [VCHPEP126/144]	2+ primary sources cited accurately. Data correctly interpreted and directly connected to claim.	At least 1 primary source cited. Connection between evidence and claim is clear.	General unit knowledge referenced without citing a source.	No evidence cited or evidence is factually incorrect.
Argument structure [VCELY]	All four scaffold blocks present and logically connected into a coherent persuasive whole.	Three of four blocks present. Logical flow is mostly clear.	Claim and some evidence present but no counter-argument or clear summary.	A list of points without connecting reasoning.

Criterion	A — Excellent	B — Proficient	C — Developing	D/E — Beginning
Counter-argument [VCHPEP126/144]	Accurately represents the opposing argument, then refutes it with specific evidence.	Identifies an opposing argument and addresses it; refutation is partial.	Mentions opposing arguments exist but does not engage substantively.	No counter-argument acknowledged.
Health knowledge [VCHPEP125/143]	Unit terminology used accurately and fluently. Statistics correct and contextualised.	Key terms mostly accurate. One or two minor factual imprecisions.	Some unit terminology with inconsistencies. One significant factual error.	Limited use of unit content. Significant factual errors present.
Communication [VCELY]	Confident, clear delivery. Maintains audience engagement. Responds fluently in crossfire.	Clear delivery. Occasional reference to notes. Crossfire responses are substantive.	Hesitant but intelligible. Relies heavily on notes. Brief crossfire responses.	Unclear or inaudible. Unable to respond to crossfire without prompting.

Student Self-Assessment — After the Debate

Rate yourself honestly: 4 = Strongly agree 3 = Mostly agree 2 = Partly agree 1 = Not yet

My opening clearly stated my position in one sentence	4 ☐	3 ☐	2 ☐	1 ☐
I cited at least one specific statistic with its source	4 ☐	3 ☐	2 ☐	1 ☐
I explained WHY my evidence proved my claim — not just stated it	4 ☐	3 ☐	2 ☐	1 ☐
I acknowledged an opposing argument and directly refuted it	4 ☐	3 ☐	2 ☐	1 ☐
I used water safety terminology from the unit accurately	4 ☐	3 ☐	2 ☐	1 ☐
I listened actively to opposing arguments — not just waited for my turn	4 ☐	3 ☐	2 ☐	1 ☐
I responded in crossfire with substance rather than deflection	4 ☐	3 ☐	2 ☐	1 ☐

One thing I argued well:

One thing I would do differently next time: